other, threw out the worms, and started eating what was available." Karpov promised that the situation would improve as soon as a ship with new food supplies reached a nearby port. The soldiers did not revolt, but their stomachs did. Voropaev wrote later: "I don't know whether it was from the worms or from the water that we drank directly from tubes lying on the ground, but dysentery appeared in the regiment and soon reached epidemic proportions. Out of the total personnel of about 1,300 men, more than 800 found themselves in the 'machine-gun companies'—an expression that became almost official."[9]

Kennedy spoke on the evening of October 22. The next morning at 8:00 a.m. Cuba time, General Statsenko put his entire division on high alert. By then he had under his command almost eight thousand Soviet officers and soldiers, thirty-six R-12 missiles, and the same number of warheads for them. Colonel Ivan Sidorov's first launching battery of intermediate ballistic missiles was ready on October 8, the second on October 12. By October 18, he recalled, his entire regiment was combat-ready (General Statsenko gave the date of October 20 in his report). By that date Sidorov's regiment was prepared to launch nuclear missiles against targets in the United States on two and a half hours' notice. There was one caveat: in order to fire, they needed nuclear warheads to be delivered to the site. That was just a matter of time, as the warheads were already in Cuba. And the Soviets had all the time they needed: Sidorov's missiles were ready to go two days before Kennedy's television address.

On October 24, Statsenko ordered the commanders of two other regiments, Colonels Sidorov and Bandilovsky, to "share" some of their fuel and other equipment with the missile regiment under the command of Colonel Soloviev, whose equipment never reached Cuba because of the blockade. They did as ordered. By October 25, Bandilovsky's entire regiment and one missile squadron of Soloviev's regiment were also on high alert. On the night of October 26, nuclear warheads were delivered from central storage to Sidorov's positions. By October 27 he was not just on high alert and ready to fire his missiles but also fully equipped to attack the United States with nuclear weapons. Kennedy's worst nightmare had suddenly become a reality.[10]